

JON BAKER

Baker Survives the Fourteenth

A quintuple bogey threatened to sink him, but a brace of closing pars gave Jon Baker the best net score of the day and sole control of the TEG 4 Trophy.

Jon Baker's opening round at Royal Ashdown Forest in TEG 1 was a study in endurance. He traded the Trophy lead back and forth through the front nine and into the back. He drew level at the 5th, at the 7th, at the 13th and again at the 15th. Never clear, never gone. Then came the 14th, the hardest hole on the course, and the round very nearly ended there. A quintuple bogey 9. On another day that is the whole story.

He answered at once. Pars at the 15th and the 16th, not a gross shot dropped across the pair, delivered with the air of a man tidying up after somebody else's accident. The composure held to the last. Baker's net 2 stood as the best Trophy score of the day in a field of five, and the next-best score was 14. He had gone from catastrophe to the finest recovery on the property in the space of two holes.

AT A GLANCE

ROUND OF THE DAY

Jon BAKER (+2)

TROPHY LEAD

Jon BAKER, 3 ahead

GREEN JACKET LEAD

David MULLIN, 3 ahead

ROUND NET VP

JB +2 | DM +5 | GW +8 | SN +10 | HM +14

ROUND GROSS

DM +23 | JB +26 | SN +28 | HM +32 | GW +36

AFTER R1 • TROPHY

JB +2 | DM +5 | GW +8 | SN +10 | HM +14

AFTER R1 • GREEN JACKET

DM +23 | JB +26 | SN +28 | HM +32 | GW +36

THE RACES

Two Leaders, One Ruthless Course

David Mullin's birdie recoveries hand him the Green Jacket lead even as Henry Meller's 12 at the short 11th buries him at the bottom of the Wooden Spoon.

Round one of the 2011 TEG at Royal Ashdown Forest's Old Course split the field cleanly into the fortunate and the doomed. Henry Meller's afternoon was defined by a single number. He took 12 at the short par-3 11th, stroke index 3 and one of the hardest holes on the course. Nine over par. It was his own worst hole, and the worst posted anywhere in TEG history to that point. A

double bogey at the 7th had already deposited him at the bottom of the 2011 TEG Wooden Spoon field, so the 11th was less a collapse than a confirmation. He closed the round anchored there.

David Mullin began no better. A triple bogey at the 5th sent him to the very bottom of the Spoon

standings, which by then was becoming a crowded address. He replied twice, breaking bogey-or-worse runs with birdies at the 10th and the 13th, and by the close of play he led the 2011 TEG Green Jacket. Jon Baker sat atop the 2011 TEG Trophy standings.

GREGG WILLIAMS

One Birdie, Then Freefall

A single birdie briefly put Gregg Williams top of the Trophy table before a 22-shot collapse over the closing nine buried the round for good.

Gregg Williams's opening round at Royal Ashdown Forest had two moods and no middle. It began badly. From the 2nd to the 6th he shipped 13 gross shots, the centrepiece being a quadruple bogey 8 at the par-4 4th. The 4th is the easiest hole on the course. The run also left him three holes without a net par and dropped him to the bottom of the TEG 16 Wooden Spoon race.

Then, briefly, order. A bogey at the 7th ended the run of bogeys-or-worse. A birdie at the 8th completed the rescue and sent him to the outright lead of the TEG 16 Trophy on net scoring. For a short while, Gregg Williams was the best golfer in the tournament.

It did not survive the back nine. From the 10th to the 18th he bled 22 shots, four doubles and three triples among them, with bogey-or-worse at the 14th, the hardest hole out there. He finished with the worst gross score of the round. The lead had been a rumour, and the rumour was corrected.

RECORDS & PERSONAL BESTS

Notable achievements: TEG 4, Round 1

RARE FEATS

— Henry Meller runs up a 12 (+9) at the 11th — a new TEG-record and career-worst on a par-3